

PCS Oriion Silver Magic Value PC

Not as magical

Similar in design and aesthetic appeal to its elder sibling, the Value PC uses the all-metallic framework for its CPU, and the silver-black theme for the rest of the peripherals.

It has a Pentium 4 1.7 GHz mounted on an Intel 845GLAD motherboard with 256 MB DDR RAM. The motherboard has a LAN controller, a six-channel sound card and three PCI slots, but lacks an AGP port, which is a must when upgrading to a better video card. The multimedia keyboard and the ball mouse is the same that comes with the Performance PC. The Value PC also comes pre-loaded with Windows XP home edition, but does not come with any other bundled software.

In performance, the Value PC could hardly match the 2.4 GHz processor PCs, finishing last in the processor tests. It took around 55 minutes to complete the PovRay test, while the rest took 40 minutes. Owing to the onboard video controller, the scene was no different in the gaming test; it could hardly give the performance needed to play the latest games such as *Halo* and *Warcraft III*. The Value PC also gave a dismal hard drive performance like its elder sibling.

Priced at Rs 31,900, the Value PC is a decent buy as it offers you an original Intel motherboard and 256 MB DDR RAM. It's great for typical office work, Internet surfing and for watching movies, but don't bank on it to play games.



Price: Rs 31,900
+ Decent features
- Motherboard lacks AGP slot

Oriion Silver Magic Value B-	
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Build quality	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■

Zenith Value PC

Zenith for the masses...

The value PC has a dark-grey chassis, with a metallic-silver finish for the front. The 15-inch monitor also has the same metallic grey treatment.

It's powered with an Intel Celeron 2 GHz, coupled to a Gigabyte motherboard, based on the Intel 845GV chipset with 128 MB DDR RAM. The motherboard, however, does not offer much option for future upgrades—the AGP slot is missing. However, a six-channel sound and an onboard LAN controller are included. The multimedia keyboard and the mouse sported a jazzy finish that spoils the appeal of the otherwise good-looking system. The choice of an operating system and



other software comes at an extra cost.

Though powered by a Celeron, the system showed average performance. Processor-intensive tasks took a long time to accomplish. In fact, it finished last in the PovRay test, taking around an hour to complete it. In the gaming tests, the results were pretty much the same, and the absence of any graphics card is sorely felt. In the ZDbench tests, the business application test failed, due to the scanty RAM in the system.

The Value PC is attractively priced at Rs 20,000, which excludes the operating system and taxes. However, even with all the added cost, it would be dearer by just Rs 4,000. Zenith has done its homework right and offers an excellent proposition—especially, if you need a PC just to browse the Internet and run some light office applications.

Price: Rs 20,000
+ Attractive price
- Lacks a performance punch

Zenith Value PC A-	
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Build quality	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■

HCL EzeeBee PC

Easily wins

Targeted at the value segment, the chic-looking EzeeBee is painted in black all around, with the face painted in matte silver, and it scores a 7 out of 10 in the looks department.

It comes with an Athlon XP 1200+ mounted on a Gigabyte motherboard, with an enormous 256 MB DDR RAM. The motherboard had a 4X AGP slot that allows you to upgrade to a better graphics card in the future. Similarly, the motherboard also offers integrated six-channel sound, a LAN controller and USB 2.0 ports. The speakers did not make it to our test lab. The scanty software bundle includes PowerDVD software and Nero burning Rom; the OS comes at an extra cost.

The HCL EzeeBee was a better performer than the Compaq S5010iL. Due to its processor's higher clock speeds, the S5010iL overpowered the humble EzeeBee in the processor sub-system test, but with minimal differences. The better graphics controller offered more frame-rates in *UT2003*. Similarly, the *Quake III* tests gave playable frame-rates, except in the case of the higher resolution tests. The EzeeBee beat the Compaq PC in the memory test with significant differences, and also showed better performance in the hard disk test. This was also the case in the Multi-tasking test, where it beat the hide out of the Compaq system.

Priced at Rs 27,500, it's a good buy if you consider the package it gives you, compared to the Zenith Value PC and the Compaq AMD PC. It wins the best performance as well as the best value award, without a doubt.

Price: Rs 26,500
+ Great value for money
- Needs a better graphic card

HCL EzeeBee PC A-	
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Build quality	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■